Lesson 27: Cohesion 1: Transition Words and Known-to-New Sentences

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.7 Cohesion and Transition Words; 2.8 "Known to New" Sentence Structure.

In this lesson

You learn two ways to make the sentences of a paragraph "stick together": academic transition words, and the "known to new" order of information, in a chain or a fork pattern. You practise with sentences about stereotypes and stereotype threat, and then revise a body paragraph of your own essay. Cohesive writing lets a lecturer follow your reasoning without effort.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what cohesion is and name five ways to create it within a paragraph.
- Replace sentence-initial "and", "but" and "so" with academic transition words that fit the meaning.
- Use transition words correctly: at the start of a sentence, followed by a comma, and not too often.
- Order information from known to new, using the chain pattern and the fork pattern.
- Revise weakly connected sentences by changing their structure, switching between active and passive, or using pronouns and synonyms.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
cohesion	how well your writing "sticks" together, so readers understand each sentence and the main idea	Screws and hinges hold the parts of a door together.
transition word	a word or phrase that shows how two sentences are connected	However, As a result, Furthermore
FANBOYS	the coordinating conjunctions *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so*	avoid them at the start of academic sentences
addition	more information of the same type	Moreover, Furthermore, In addition, Also
contrast	a difference or an opposite idea	However, Nevertheless, On the other hand
result	a consequence of the previous idea	Thus, Therefore, As a result, Consequently, Hence

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
repetitive	using the same thing too many times	Do not always use the same transition word.
known information	information the reader already has from earlier sentences	"In this chapter, McRaney and her colleagues ..."
new information	information the sentence adds	"... discuss a number of studies ..."
known-to-new structure	starting a sentence with known information and ending it with new information	the usual order in English
chain pattern	the new information at the end of one sentence becomes the known start of the next	a chain, each link joined to the next
fork pattern	one topic is introduced, and each following sentence adds new information about it	a fork: one handle, several tines
synonym	a word or phrase with the same or a similar meaning	Claude Steele ... the researcher

Rules and explanations

What is cohesion?

Cohesion is how well your writing sticks together. With cohesion, readers understand each sentence and also the main idea. Winer and Wadell give five ways to create cohesion **within** paragraphs:

1. transition words (this lesson);
2. demonstrative pronouns (Lesson 28);
3. demonstrative adjectives + summary nouns (Lesson 28);
4. parallel structure (Lesson 5);
5. "known to new" sentence structure (this lesson).

Transition words

Transition words show readers **why** you connect two sentences: are you adding information, showing a contrast, or showing a result? They are the most common way of creating cohesion.

- Use them at the beginning of a sentence, followed by a comma.
- A transition word begins a new sentence; it does not join two sentences with a comma ("..., however, ..." between two sentences is a comma splice; see Lesson 4).
- Do not always use the same transition words: it sounds repetitive.
- Do not start every sentence with a transition word: it becomes boring.
- Transitions are a good tool, but not the only way to build cohesion.

Academic transitions instead of FANBOYS

In speech and casual writing, we often start sentences with *and, but* or *so*. In academic writing, avoid starting sentences with FANBOYS; use these instead (Table 2.7.1):

Instead of	Purpose	Academic transition words
And	add more of the same type of information	Moreover, Furthermore, In addition, Also,
But	show contrast	However, Nevertheless, On the contrary, On the other hand,
So	show a result	Thus, Therefore, As a result, Consequently, Hence,

The book's example sentences for the table are in Exercise 3.

Two of the contrast words are special. *On the contrary* follows a negative statement and says that the opposite is true. *On the other hand* introduces another side of the same question. For a simple contrast, use *However*.

Known to new

In English, a sentence usually starts with information the reader already knows and ends with new information about it. Readers first understand the general idea and then focus on what is new. Compare the two passages in "Noticing cohesion" (Exercise 1): they contain the same words in a different order.

Chain pattern. The new information at the end of one sentence becomes the known information at the start of the next:

- "Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test? **This** [known] is just one of the findings reported by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues [new] ..."
- "**In this chapter, McRaney and her colleagues** [known] discuss a number of studies ... [new]."

Fork pattern. One topic (the handle) is introduced first; each following sentence (a tine) adds new information about that same topic. Example: "With planning, educators can reduce the impacts of stereotype threats." The next three sentences each give one way to do it.

Three strategies for linking sentences in a chain:

1. Change the structure of a sentence so that known information comes first and new information last.
2. Change a sentence from active to passive (or from passive to active) to keep the same topic across sentences.
3. Use pronouns and synonyms to connect sentences.

Small mistakes in the lesson material

In 2.7, "These words how your readers ..." should be "These words **show** your readers ...". In 2.8, "Clause Steele" is **Claude** Steele, "stereotype thread" is stereotype **threat**, the second strategy should read "(or from **passive to active**)", and the last bracket in the fork example should say the **third** piece of new information.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic sentences often begin with "wa" (and) or "fa" (so), so an English sentence that starts with *And* or *So* can feel natural. In academic English, use a transition word (*Moreover, As a result*) or join the two ideas in one sentence.

Practice

Exercise 1. Noticing cohesion. Read Passage 1 and Passage 2 in "Noticing cohesion". Which is easier to understand, and why? Which pattern does the easier passage use?

Exercise 2. Adding transition words. In "Adding appropriate transition words" ("Stereotyping helps us quickly understand ..."), add at least two transition words from Table 2.7.1.

Exercise 3. Replacing FANBOYS. These are the book's example sentences, written with FANBOYS. Replace each FANBOY with an academic transition that fits the meaning. Which transitions would not fit?

1. New stereotypes are being created from world events all the time. And they become even more problematic when people harm others based on these stereotypes.
2. While her roommate had a single story about African people, Adichie had a negative stereotype about Mexicans because she heard an "endless story" of news coverage of desperate immigrants crossing the U.S. border illegally and scamming the healthcare system. But she changed her perspective when she visited Mexico and she realized that Mexicans are hard-working and happy too.
3. Adichie's roommate only knew "one story" about people from Africa. So she was surprised Adichie could speak English and knew how to use a stove.

Exercise 4. Too many transitions? Read the paragraph in "Using transitions effectively" (it begins "Lastly, I have two words of warning ...").

1. Find the five transition words and say what each one does.
2. Why does the writer say, "I probably used too many transition words in this paragraph"?

Exercise 5. Writing with the chain pattern. What word or words go in the blank? "The first main researcher on stereotype threat was Claude Steele, who focused on how it impacted African American university students. _____ began to notice racial minorities and women sometimes performed lower than their abilities."

Exercise 6. Revising with the chain pattern. Use the three strategies to connect these sentences more strongly: "Stereotypes are often the result of media exposure. Children see thousands of images of different groups on television, in video games, and in movies over the years. Many images of non-white groups tend to be biased or simplistic."

Exercise 7. The fork pattern. Read the fork example in the lesson material ("With planning, educators can reduce the impacts of stereotype threats ...").

1. What is the handle (the known topic)?
2. What three pieces of new information are the tines?
3. Which transition words introduce them?
4. In the third sentence, which word refers back to the known topic?

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is a paragraph from my essay: [paste]. Highlight every sentence that starts with And, But or So, and every transition word. Do my transitions fit the meaning? Do I use too many?"
- "Give me eight pairs of sentences about memory or sleep from PSYC 110. For each pair, I will choose a transition for addition, contrast or result, and explain my choice."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Mark the known and the new information in each sentence. Where does the chain break?"
- "Ask me to explain stereotype threat in five sentences using the fork pattern. Then tell me if each sentence adds new information about the same topic."
- "Check my answer to Exercise 6."

Read aloud

Pause briefly after each comma that follows a transition word.

1. Stereotyping helps us quickly understand or make a decision about others. However, it gives people surface knowledge.
2. Adichie's roommate only knew "one story" about people from Africa. As a result, she was surprised Adichie could speak English.
3. New stereotypes are being created from world events all the time. Furthermore, they become even more problematic when people harm others.
4. With planning, educators can reduce the impacts of stereotype threats. For example, educators can be careful not to frame tests as measures of ability.
5. Lastly, teaching students about stereotype threat can help the students to resist it.

Writing task

Revise one or two body paragraphs of the essay you drafted in Lessons 24 to 26 for cohesion (if you have no draft, write one body paragraph of 150 to 200 words on stereotypes, or on a PSYC 110 topic such as memory or stress, and revise it). Follow the book's steps:

1. Highlight every sentence that starts with a FANBOY, and replace it with a transition from Table 2.7.1 (or join the two sentences).
2. Underline every transition word. Is it right for the meaning? Is it followed by a comma?

3. Check each pair of sentences: does the second sentence start with something the reader already knows? Rewrite weak links with the three strategies.
4. Decide whether each paragraph follows a chain or a fork pattern, and make the pattern clear.

Self-editing checklist:

- No sentence starts with *And, But* or *So*.
- Each transition word matches the relationship (addition, contrast or result).
- Each transition word at the start of a sentence is followed by a comma, and none joins two sentences with only a comma.
- I do not repeat the same transition, and not every sentence starts with one.
- Most sentences begin with known information and end with new information.
- I used pronouns and synonyms to link sentences without repeating the same noun every time.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Jennifer L. Eberhardt, "How Racial Bias Works — and How to Disrupt It" (TED talk, quoted in Exercise 2): https://www.ted.com/talks/jennifer_l_eberhardt_how_racial_bias_works_and_how_to_disrupt_it

Answer key

Exercise 1 Passage 2 (book). It follows the known-to-new order: each sentence begins with information the reader knows and ends with new information. Passage 1 jumps around from topic to topic. Passage 2 uses the chain pattern (book).

Exercise 2 (book) "Stereotyping helps us quickly understand or make a decision about others. **However,** it gives people surface knowledge and a limited understanding of other people. **As a result,** people are all labeled and everyone categorizes others, which is necessary to do in order to make quick judgments. **Furthermore,** Jennifer Eberhardt points out that 'the content of those stereotypes is culturally generated and culturally specific.'" Other words from the same group are also correct: *Nevertheless* for *However*; *Therefore, Consequently, Thus* or *Hence* for *As a result*; *Moreover* or *In addition* for *Furthermore*.

Exercise 3

1. Furthermore, (the book's sentence). Moreover, In addition, and Also, are also correct. Contrast and result words do not fit: the sentence adds information.
2. However, (the book's sentence). Nevertheless, is also possible. *On the contrary* does not fit (the first sentence is not a negative statement that the second rejects), and *On the other hand* does not fit (the second sentence tells what happened later, not another side of a question).
3. As a result, (the book's sentence). Therefore, Consequently, Thus, and Hence, are also correct.

Exercise 4

1. *Lastly* introduces the final point; *First* begins a sequence; *In addition* adds information; *For example* introduces an example; *To sum up* introduces a summary.
2. Every sentence starts with a transition word, which is exactly what the paragraph warns against. The writer is showing the problem on purpose.

Exercise 5 Steele (book). *He* is also correct: Steele was introduced at the end of the first sentence, so he is now known information.

Exercise 6 (example answer) "Stereotypes are often the result of media exposure. Through the media, such as television, video games, and movies, children see thousands of images of different groups over the years. Many of these images, especially those of non-white groups, tend to be biased or simplistic." (The second sentence now starts with the known idea, the media; the third starts with "these images", which points back to the end of the second.)

Exercise 7

1. "With planning, educators can reduce the impacts of stereotype threats."
2. Educators can be careful not to frame tests as measures of ability; they should make sure that their classrooms do not trigger stereotypes by showing the accomplishments of only certain groups; teaching students about stereotype threat can help them resist it.
3. For example, Even more importantly, Lastly.
4. "they" (= educators).

My notes